



**THE
KEYS
COACH**

FREE LESSON BOOK

Thumb Voicings

The Essential Guide

[THEKEYSCOACH.COM](https://thekeyscorch.com)



This lesson book accompanies the full video lesson on The Keys Coach YouTube channel.

Introduction

from Adam Saunders



In this lesson, you'll learn a simple voicing system that makes your chords sound smooth, rich, and professional. And the magic? It's all in the thumbs. I'll walk you through the exact shapes I rely on 95% of the time, and how to use them in real chord progressions so everything flows and sounds intentional—no more clunky jumps.

If we haven't met, I'm Adam—a professional keys player, educator, and founder of The Keys Coach. My goal is to help you play with more creativity, confidence, and freedom—so you can truly express yourself and take your playing to the next level!

Let's dive in!

➤ [**Download the Backing Track: Click Here**](#)

Foundations

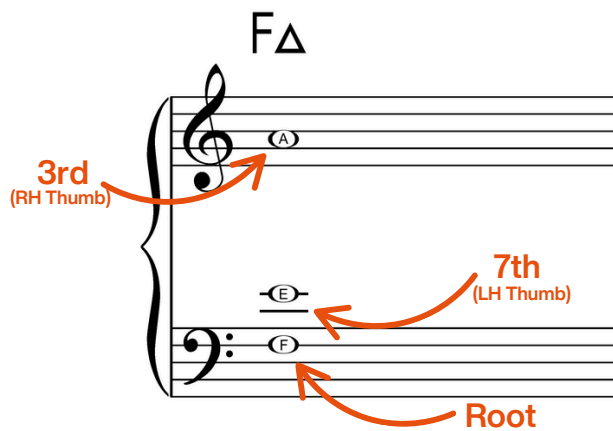
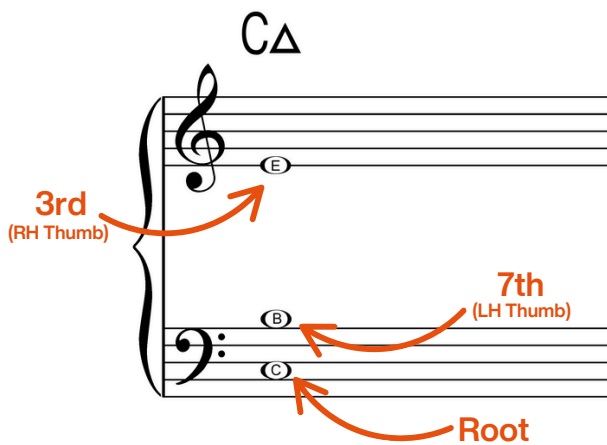
The Core Voicing

video 0:50

There are three key things to remember when playing these voicings:

- Your left hand little finger plays the **root note**
- Your left hand thumb plays the **seventh**
- Your right hand thumb plays the **third**

So, for example:



These voicings are called Thumb Voicings because our thumbs are playing the key notes in the chord—known as the **guide tones**.

These are the notes that give the chord its character, whether it's a major 7, minor 7, or dominant 7.



“Take the time to really lock in the foundations of this voicing—it’ll make everything that comes later so much clearer. Focus on your thumbs and get these shapes secure.”

— Adam

The Next Layer

Adding Colour

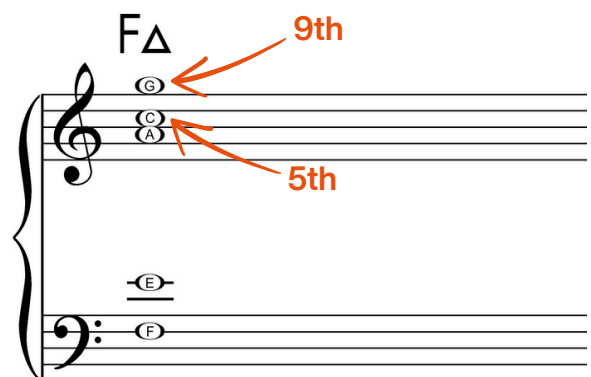
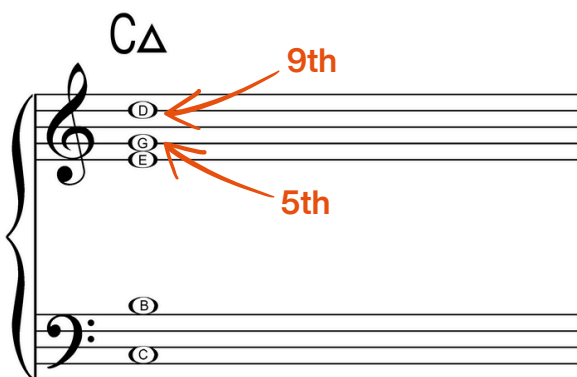
video 2:16

We're now going to add some colour to the chords with the rest of our right hand.

- Your second finger in your right hand will play the **fifth**
- Your little finger in your right hand will play the **ninth**

The ninth is often called an extension—it's a note that adds extra colour to the chord. It's the same note as the second.

So, for example:



Try This...

Experiment with using this same formula on minor 7, dominant 7, and other major 7 chords.

Begin with the root note, add your thumbs, then layer in the extra notes on top.

Applying The Formula

Voicing a ii–V–I

video 3:43

A ii–V–I progression is one of the most common chord progressions out there. You’ll find it in countless songs—especially jazz standards.

In the key of C, a ii–V–I progression looks like this:



We can use our thumb voicings to play this progression.

But here’s the key: when we move between chords, we need to flip the notes in the voicing to make the transition smoother.

Each time we change chords, we:

- Flip the **seventh** and **third**
- Flip the **fifth** and **ninth**



“Once you’ve got this solid in the key of C, try moving it to a few other keys—F, Bb, or G are great places to start.”

— Adam



Tweaking The Voicings

Adding Some Crunch

video 7:15

We're now going to tweak one of the chords in our sequence to give it a bit more crunch—something harmonically richer and juicier.

In a ii–V–I progression, the chord that usually gets altered first is the middle chord—the V chord (in this case, G7).

We're going to change the 9th to a flat 9th by bringing it down a semitone (or half-step).

Musical notation for a ii–V–I progression. The first measure is Dm7 (D minor 7), the second is G7b9 (G dominant 7 flat 9), and the third is CΔ (C major). The notation shows the notes for each chord in both treble and bass staves. An orange arrow points to the flat 9th (Ab) in the G7b9 chord, with the text 'flat 9th' written in orange.

Playlist

Here are some songs from a variety of genres that feature plenty of major ii–V–I progressions—perfect for trying out these voicings in context:

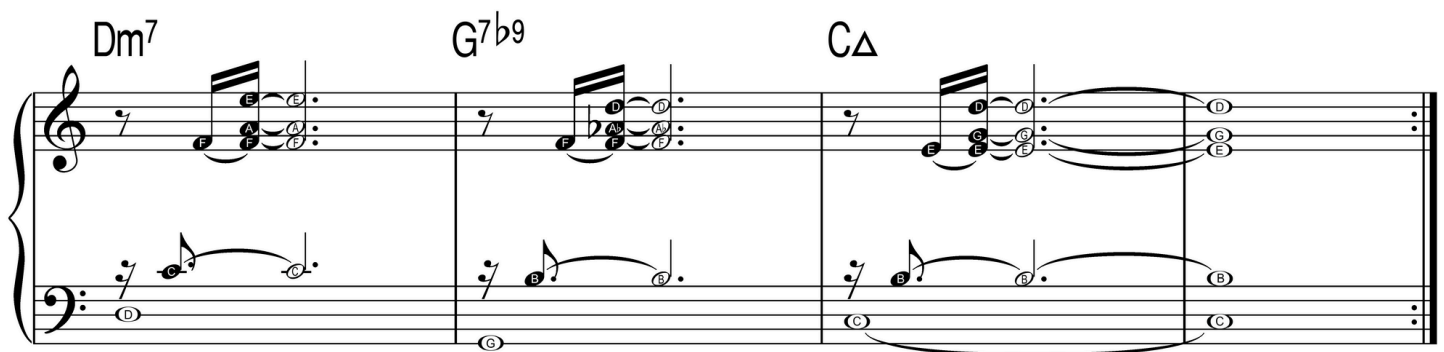
- Bill Withers – *Just The Two of Us*
- Stevie Wonder – *You Are the Sunshine of My Life*
- *But Not for Me* (jazz standard)
- Nat King Cole – *L-O-V-E*
- Norah Jones – *Don't Know Why*
- James Taylor – *Don't Let Me Be Lonely Tonight*
- Roberta Flack – *Killing Me Softly*
- Earth, Wind & Fire – *After the Love Has Gone*

Next Steps

Inject Some Rhythm

video 9:48

Now let's add a simple rhythm to these voicings to really bring them to life.



Practice this along with the drum groove (you'll find the link at the bottom of page 2 in this lesson book).

You can also experiment with adding some improvised rhythm on the Cmaj7 chord, just like Adam demonstrates in the video.



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